

03

The Business

What to charge, how to run a client, and how to turn a production system into recurring revenue.

The part most people skip

Knowing how to make the video is maybe 40% of the business. The other 60% is pricing it correctly, running the client cleanly, and not getting yourself into legal trouble putting someone's face on the internet.

There are a lot of people who can now generate a decent AI clip. There are very few who can take a payment, deliver on a schedule, handle a revision without losing money, and produce paperwork when a platform or a lawyer asks for it. That gap is your entire business.

THE REFRAME THAT CHANGES YOUR PRICING

You are not selling videos. You are selling **a production line** — the ability to reliably put a specific person into unlimited scenes, on a schedule, with paperwork. Videos are the output. Price against what the production line replaces, not against your generation bill.

What to charge

The fastest way to underprice yourself is to think "it cost me \$56 to generate, so I'll charge \$200." Your client is not buying compute. They are buying an outcome they cannot produce themselves.

Three tiers that work

TIER	WHAT THEY GET	RANGE	WHO IT'S FOR
Pilot	Identity kit built, 3–5 videos, a performance report	\$1,500 – \$3,500 <i>one time</i>	New client who needs proof before committing
Retainer	Identity kit, 15–30 videos/month, variants, scheduling	\$4,000 – \$12,000 <i>per month</i>	Brand or creator with an audience already
Build & hand off	You build the system and train their team to run it	\$8,000 – \$25,000 <i>one time</i>	Company that wants it in-house

Compute is billed on top, at cost, with receipts. This is worth doing deliberately — it makes you a partner rather than a vendor defending a markup, and it means you never have to argue with yourself about whether a re-roll is affordable. Put a monthly ceiling on it so nobody is surprised.

The pilot is your best sales tool

Nobody wants to sign a retainer with someone whose work they have not seen. The pilot solves that, and it gets the identity kit built — which is the expensive, slow part. Once that kit exists, every subsequent video is fast and cheap for you. The pilot is how you get paid to build the thing that makes the rest of the relationship profitable.

ASK FOR A PERFORMANCE KICKER

A bonus when a video crosses an agreed view threshold, or a small percentage of attributable sales. Most clients say yes because it costs them nothing unless you win. It is often worth more than the retainer — one breakout piece can outearn a year of monthly invoices — and it aligns you with the outcome instead of the deliverable count.

Pricing mistakes that will cost you

- **Charging per video.** It punishes you for efficiency and invites haggling over count. Charge for the month.
- **Unlimited revisions.** Two rounds included, then hourly. Write it down before you start.
- **Eating compute silently.** Pass it through. Clients respect a line item; they resent a surprise.
- **Quoting before the shot graph exists.** Write the graph, run the math, then quote.
- **Doing the identity kit for free "to show them."** That is the most valuable thing you build. Charge for it.

Running the client

Intake — get these before you quote

- ☐ Whose likeness is being used, and can they sign for it themselves
- ☐ Which platforms it will be published on
- ☐ Whether any of it will run as paid advertising (this changes the rules — see below)
- ☐ How many videos per month, and who approves scripts
- ☐ Whether they have usable photos and audio already, or you are shooting
- ☐ What "done" looks like — a posted video, or files delivered to their editor
- ☐ Any subject matter that is off limits

The approval rhythm that keeps you sane

Chasing approvals twice a day will end the relationship inside a month. Batch it.

- 1 **Once a week**, send every script for the coming week in one message.
- 2 Client approves in one pass. Nothing gets generated before that.
- 3 **Daily**, you produce and publish against approved scripts without further check-ins.
- 4 **Once a week**, send performance numbers and what you are changing because of them.

SCRIPT APPROVAL BEFORE GENERATION, NEVER AFTER

If your client is a public figure, a hallucinated specific claim in their voice — a number, a prediction, a recommendation — is the one mistake with no recovery. Approval happens on the written script, before you spend a cent. This is also a selling point: it shows you understand that their credibility is the asset, not your video.

Handling revisions without losing money

This is where the whole system pays off. When a client says "I don't like the third shot," you re-roll one shot for about four dollars and send it back the same day. Someone working the slot-machine way regenerates the whole video, spends \$56, and takes two days.

Say this out loud on the sales call. "If you don't like something, we fix that piece, not the whole video." It sounds small. To anyone who has worked with a video team before, it is the most attractive thing you will say.

Likeness, consent and disclosure

This section is short and it matters more than everything else combined. Read it once and set it up correctly; then it never bothers you again.

Two separate obligations

People confuse these constantly. They are independent. You need both.

1 — PERMISSION TO USE THE LIKENESS

Using a real person's AI-generated likeness without documented authorization is a violation on every major platform, *separately* from any AI labeling question. It is also a right-of-publicity issue in most US states. Get it in writing before you generate.

2 — DISCLOSING THAT IT IS AI

Realistic AI-generated depictions of people need to be labeled on the major platforms. The toggle exists in the upload flow. Use it every time, on every platform.

DISCLOSURE DOES NOT HURT YOU

This is the part people get wrong out of fear. On the major platforms, correctly disclosed AI content remains eligible for monetization and creator payout programs, and disclosure does not suppress reach. Some platforms detect synthetic media automatically and label it for you — and *undisclosed* content is what gets distribution reduced or removed. So the honest path is also the higher-performing one. Verify current specifics with each platform before you launch; these policies do get updated.

What your release needs to cover

Adapt this list into a document. Have a lawyer look at it before you use it on a real client — it is a few hundred dollars against the whole business.

- Full legal name of the person whose likeness is used
- Explicit permission to create and publish AI-generated **video and voice** of them
- Scope — which brands, which channels, what subject matter
- Term, and their right to revoke going forward
- Who approves each piece before publication
- Prohibited uses, named specifically: political endorsement, personalized financial or medical advice, third-party product endorsement without separate approval, anything placing them in a false light
- Who owns the generated assets and the identity kit
- Where the source photos, source audio and the signed release are archived

IF IT IS RUNNING AS ADVERTISING

Paid placement raises the bar. Platforms generally require consent documentation on file for ads using a real person's digital likeness — legal name, permitted use, campaign duration, signed release — and some require it uploaded directly in their ads manager. Write your release to that standard from day one even if you are only doing organic, so you are not redoing paperwork later.

House rules worth adopting

- 1 **Give the client a kill switch.** One message and it comes down, no argument. Say this on the sales call. It converts.
- 2 **No real third parties.** No other identifiable people, no real companies as villains, no real logos.
- 3 **No fabricated results or testimonials.** No invented customers, no invented numbers.
- 4 **No news framing.** Never generate someone appearing to react to a real event as though it were filmed.
- 5 **Keep the receipts.** Scripts, approvals, prompts, releases — archived. If anything is ever questioned you can reconstruct the whole chain in ten minutes.

Scaling to daily output

Two videos a day sounds impossible until you separate *generating* from *publishing*. Remember the variant engine from Book One: one generated piece is five published assets. Two generations a day is roughly ten posts a day. You are not producing ten things. You are producing two and packaging them five ways.

A week that actually works

WHEN	TIME	WHAT
Sunday	90 min	Write the week's premises, draft all shot graphs, send every script for approval in one batch
Mon–Fri	2 × 40 min	Generate → review → lock → assemble → cut variants → schedule
Friday	30 min	Pull numbers, update what is working, kill what is not

If a production day takes more than ninety minutes of your attention, something is wrong, and it is almost always that concepts were not banked in advance. The Sunday session is not optional — it is the thing that makes the weekdays mechanical.

What to actually measure

Ignore likes. Track these:

METRIC	WHY IT MATTERS
3-second hold rate	Whether your hook works. Everything downstream depends on it.
Completion rate	Whether your ending works. Drives distribution harder than any other signal.
Shares	The truest virality signal. Someone risking their own reputation on your video.
Profile / link clicks	The one that turns views into money.

Where it breaks, and what to do

SYMPTOM	REAL CAUSE	FIX
Views collapsed across the board	Cadence outran quality	Drop to one a day, raise the bar, rebuild trust
A format that worked stops working	Fatigue — normal around 20 episodes	Rotate formats, rest that one for three weeks
Costs creeping up	Re-rolling whole videos out of habit	Re-roll shots. Run the math before generating.
Client approval bottleneck	Approving daily instead of weekly	Move to the Sunday batch
You are exhausted	Generating for every post instead of using variants	Two generations, ten posts. Go back to Book One, Layer 4.

Finding the first three clients

You do not need a big audience. You need three people who already have one.

- 1 Make one spec piece for a specific person** using public photos and a script you write, and send it to them directly. Not a pitch — the actual video. This converts better than anything else you can do, because they can see it instead of imagining it. Do not publish spec work anywhere; it is a private demo, sent to that one person, and delete it if they pass.
- 2 Target people with an audience and no production capacity.** Coaches, educators, authors, local personalities, podcast hosts. They have the demand and no way to serve it.
- 3 Lead with the production line, not the technology.** "You could post a short film with you in it twice a week without stepping in front of a camera" beats any explanation of how it works.
- 4 Sell the pilot, not the retainer.** Small yes first. The retainer conversation is much easier after they have watched something good with their own face in it.
- 5 Ask for the referral at the win.** The moment a piece performs, that is when you ask who else they know. Not at invoice time.

YOUR UNFAIR ADVANTAGE

Most people pitching this can generate a clip. Almost none of them can promise a schedule, hand over a release, keep an editable timeline, and fix one shot without redoing the video. You now can. That is not a small edge — it is the difference between a freelancer and a studio.

Your first 30 days

WEEK	DO THIS
Week 1	Build one identity kit (yourself or a willing friend). Run the full loop once on a 45-second piece. Publish nothing — this one is for learning.
Week 2	Make three pieces with the same identity. Time yourself. Find where you are slow and fix that specifically.
Week 3	Pick a target client. Make one spec piece for them. Send it directly with a two-sentence note.
Week 4	Send five more. Have your release template and pilot pricing ready before anyone says yes.

The single biggest predictor of whether this works for you is whether you build the identity kit in week one. Everyone who stalls, stalls there — because it is the one step that requires leaving the computer. Do it first and the rest is mechanical.

You have the method (Book One), the parts (Book Two) and the business (Book Three). The two videos show both books in practice, start to finish, with nothing edited out.